

SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: PHILANDER SMITH UNIVERSITY

TRADITIONAL

On-Site Review: January 22-24, 2024

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

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REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 LITERACY COURSEWORK	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT
APPROACHING	APPROACHING	APPROACHING
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
CORRECTIVE ACTION STATUS		
Corrective action plan in place for this review cycle. This program is carrying out a corrective action plan with the Division covering fifteen actions.		

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	Philander Smith University
LOCATION	Little Rock, Arkansas
PROGRAM REVIEWED	Bachelor of Education elementary education licensure program, grades K-6
PATHWAY	Traditional
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2023)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	January 22-24, 2024

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY COURSEWORK

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL
APPROACHING
CRITERION RATINGS
<i>This review states one rating for the review area and discusses the criteria in narrative. It does not state a separate rating for each criterion, so none is published here.</i>
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND
Reviewers evaluated literacy coursework using syllabi, online course materials, and instructor interviews for EDUC 373 Foundations of Literacy, ELED 373 Teaching Literacy and Language Arts, and ELED 493 Disciplined Literacy. Coursework covered the core components of the science of reading, with EDUC 373 emphasizing phonological and phonemic awareness, phonics, orthography, and automatic word recognition, and ELED 373 covering fluency, vocabulary, comprehension, and writing. Reviewers found that these components were not presented in a systematic, sequential order, and that coursework lacked sufficient instruction in concepts of print, writing, assessment, and support for multilingual and diverse learners. Models of high-quality instruction were limited, and differentiation and the use of high-quality instructional materials were introduced but not embedded.
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS
• Strengthen coursework so directed teachers can scaffold instruction for multilingual learners at varied language levels • Provide instruction on explicitly teaching writing and its connection to reading, with related assignments
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA
Eight of the fifteen corrective actions target this review area.

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL
APPROACHING
CRITERION RATINGS
<i>This review states one rating for the review area and discusses the criteria in narrative. It does not state a separate rating for each criterion, so none is published here.</i>
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND
Reviewers found that the program drew on long-standing district relationships but had no formalized criteria for selecting placement schools, and that only one of ten placement schools was improving or high performing. Most directed teachers were placed in a single district across multiple grade levels, and received weekly visits and instructional coaching. Mentor selection was not yet formalized in memoranda of understanding, and mentor training covered observation tools but not high-quality instructional materials or coaching. Placements gave directed teachers few opportunities to teach writing, differentiate instruction, use assessments, or work with multilingual learners. Supervisor feedback was inconsistent, sometimes inaccurate, and focused on teacher actions rather than student learning.
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS
• Improve oral and written feedback accuracy through training with science of reading look-fors and observer reliability measures • Add earlier field opportunities to practice with high-quality instructional materials and ensure all mentors are quality literacy practitioners
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA
Six of the fifteen corrective actions target this review area.

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL
APPROACHING
CRITERION RATINGS
<i>This review states one rating for the review area and discusses the criteria in narrative. It does not state a separate rating for each criterion, so none is published here.</i>
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND
Reviewers found that the program collected grades, licensure exam results, disposition assessments, surveys, and course evaluations, but that most data was compliance driven and reviewed at the end of the semester. Statewide and retention reports were available but not used to drive improvement. Observation and feedback data did not accurately reflect directed teachers' classroom capacity, and no formal system checked supervisor, mentor, or instructor practice. A formal intervention plan and counseling-out process existed, though quality control gates lacked triggers tied to clinical performance and dispositions. Divisional and professional learning community plans were not yet consolidated into one strategic plan, and partnership agreements lacked specifics on shared goals and data.
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS
• Build and monitor a system assuring high-quality written and oral feedback data, including evaluator training • Combine divisional and professional learning community plans into one strategic plan with responsible parties and timescales
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA
Two of the fifteen corrective actions target this review area.

CORRECTIVE ACTION PLAN

Where a review identifies findings that require follow-up, the program develops a corrective action plan with the Division of Elementary and Secondary Education. The recommendations under each review area above are the reviewers' advice; the plan below is the program's formal response, monitored by the Division. Actions are grouped by the review area whose findings prompted them.

TOTAL ACTIONS	HIGH PRIORITY	MEDIUM PRIORITY	LOW PRIORITY
15	14	1	0

The plan sets out 15 corrective actions: 14 high priority and 1 medium priority. The priorities are the plan's own. Some actions target more than one review area, so the per-area counts shown under each review area add to more than the total.

ACTIONS THE PROGRAM IS TAKING

PRIORITY	ACTION	FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT	SUCCESS METRICS
HIGH RA1, RA2	Coursework-Field SoR Spiral & Assessment Alignment	Coursework is approaching; components are not consistently systematic/sequential; limited practice and assessment use.	Published SoR scope/sequence; ≥90% courses show explicit SoR objectives, modeled practice, and aligned checks; assessment map completed.
HIGH RA1	Concepts of Print (COP) Instruction & Calibration	COP instruction/practice insufficient in EDUC 373/ELED sequence.	100% candidates complete COP practice/assessment with feedback; IRR ≥0.80 for COP scoring.
HIGH RA1	Oral Language: SR to SVR & Language Structures	OL instruction approaching; need deeper links to SR/SVR and phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics, pragmatics, discourse, orthography.	OL modules embedded in methods; candidates complete ≥2 coached cycles applying OL strategies; rubric avg ≥3/4.
HIGH RA1	Phonological & Phonemic Awareness Deep Dive	Repetition across courses; need depth in isolation/blending/segmenting/add-delete-substitute and articulation for decoding/encoding.	Candidates implement ≥3 PA/phonemic routines with multiple assessments; rubric avg ≥3/4.
HIGH RA1	Phonics/Orthography/AWR Continuum & Transfer	Approaching; need coherent sequence and more explicit modeling of evidence-based practices.	New phonics/orthography sequence approved; candidates demonstrate mapping/decoding/encoding proficiency ≥80%.
HIGH RA1	Fluency Instruction & Assessment Toolkit	Fluency is below; limited instruction/application and assessment use.	Toolkit used across coursework/field; candidates administer & analyze fluency measures; rehearsal growth targets met.
MEDIUM RA1	Vocabulary (Morphology) & Text Comprehension Integration	Approaching; add explicit morphology/structural analysis, text structures, inferencing; tie to assessments/HQIM.	Each methods course includes explicit V/C modules; ≥2 modeled mini-lessons; candidate units meet rubric ≥3/4.

PRIORITY	ACTION	FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT	SUCCESS METRICS
HIGH RA1	Writing Across the Literacy Block	Writing instruction is below; need explicit modeling of the recursive process and application.	Writing mini-lessons embedded; candidates complete a writing cycle (plan-teach-assess-revise) with rubric avg $\geq 3/4$.
HIGH RA2	Early & Sequenced Field Practice with HQIM (FE1 to FE2)	Need earlier, staged practice and guaranteed HQIM exposure prior to/prior during placements.	FE1 adds weekly practice; FE2 expands to small-group/whole-class; ≥ 2 graded rehearsals per component; 100% candidates use HQIM in at least one cycle.
HIGH RA2	ML Application Cycles (Classroom, Virtual/Simulated)	ML opportunities are below; few placements with MLs and limited planning/assessment for MLs.	Each candidate completes ≥ 1 ML application cycle (classroom or simulated); fidelity $\geq 80\%$; evidence of language objectives and scaffolds.
HIGH RA2	Readers-with-Difficulties & Dyslexia-Responsive Practice	Approaching; expand Tier 1-2 intervention practice and models/simulations.	≥ 2 intervention cycles/candidate with fidelity $\geq 80\%$; PM gains evident for focus students.
HIGH RA2	Mentor & Placement Criteria (Schools + Teachers) in MOUs	Selection is approaching but informal; need formal criteria ensuring structured literacy/HQIM modeling and coaching capacity.	Updated MOUs with school/mentor criteria; mentor rubric adopted; 100% mentors meet proficiency.
HIGH RA2	Observation/Feedback Calibration + Inter-Rater Reliability (IRR)	Written/oral feedback inconsistent and sometimes inaccurate; need literacy look-fors and calibration.	IRR ≥ 0.80 among evaluators; feedback includes actionable literacy steps aligned to evidence.
HIGH RA3	Literacy Control Gates & Unified Data Dashboard	Data quality/usage variable; observation/feedback data unreliable; end-of-term reviews too late.	Gate criteria published; $\geq 90\%$ pass rate by final gate; dashboard live and reviewed each term to drive changes.
HIGH RA3	Program-Wide Strategic Improvement Plan	Multiple plans exist; need one strategic plan aligning training, field experiences, partnerships, data, goals, owners, and timelines.	Plan approved by governance; milestone tracker shows on-time completion $\geq 85\%$; quarterly progress reviews conducted.

OVERSIGHT

Each action in the plan carries an evidence requirement and a rationale tied to a review finding. The plan leaves the responsible owner and the completion timeline for program leadership to assign, so those entries are not recorded in the plan as issued and are not published here. The Division separately issued a corrective action determination for this program identifying 12 corrective actions, 6 required and 5 recommended, with one item marked no action needed. Review area assignments in the table below were made by matching each action's stated rationale to the review area whose findings it answers.

Sources: TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review, Philander Smith University, January 22-24, 2024, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2023). Philander Smith University Science of Reading Corrective Action Plan, Arkansas DESE. Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.